

HP EliteBook 8 G1a

An AI PC for modern professionals

The HP EliteBook 8 G1a, unveiled in March 2025, has finally made its way to India and from the looks of it, the G1a is part of the new wave of laptops or AI PCs with a clear focus on intelligent performance, robust security, and refined user experience. Built around AMD's Ryzen AI 7 350 processor, the EliteBook 8 G1a is a refreshing addition to HP's 2025 line-up giving consumers choice between Intel and AMD. And if this is the first time you're coming across an EliteBook then you're looking at a platform designed to empower mobile professionals who need local AI processing, enterprise-grade protection, and sleek portability. The 'local AI processing' is new, everything else has been there for years.

FEATURES

At the heart of the EliteBook 8 G1a's AI chops is its 50 TOPS NPU, which enables advanced workloads like real-time transcription, summarisation, and image enhancement without taxing the CPU or GPU. This makes for quieter operations during compute-heavy tasks.

The built-in HP AI Companion is an attempt to make generative AI accessible for the average professional. It allows users to group files into libraries and interact with them through natural language prompts. Supported formats include PDFs, Word documents, PowerPoint files, and plain text. While its ability to switch between on-device and cloud inference is commendable, the user interface needs refinement, particularly the workflow around accessing libraries, which is somewhat disjointed.

HP Smart Sense learns your usage patterns and toggles between performance and battery-saving modes,

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managing thermals. This automation contributes to a seamless experience whether in a meeting, working offline on a presentation, or casually browsing.

HP Wolf Security for Business rounds out the package with BIOS-level

protections, real-time threat containment, and secure browsing. While the average user may not see its effects day-to-day, enterprise IT departments will appreciate the always-on protection that doesn't need third-party security suites layered on top.

CPU AND MULTITASKING

The Ryzen AI 7 350 is a hybrid chip based on AMD's Zen 5 and Zen 5c architectures. With 8 cores in total (4 high-performance Zen 5 and 4 efficient Zen 5c), it supports 16 threads via simultaneous multithreading. This chip can clock up to 5 GHz on the performance cores and is designed for a 28W TDP envelope, although system tuning lets it push closer to 33W in short bursts.

In synthetic benchmarks such as Cinebench 2024, the EliteBook 8 G1a

returns a single-core score of 114 and a multi-core score of 665. These numbers place it slightly behind what the chip is theoretically capable of, especially on the multi-core front, where similar laptops have crossed the 900 mark. The culprit seems to be a combination of thermal constraints and background processes tied to HP's always-on security features. That said, in everyday use (Chrome, Zoom, Excel, and background sync tools), the laptop feels fluid, rarely stuttering even in heavy multitasking.

Boot-up times are snappy, app launches are instant, and the system never feels bogged down even when running multiple productivity and collaboration tools in tandem. Office users, content reviewers, and analysts will find this laptop more than adequate for the day-to-day load.

NEURAL PROCESSING UNIT (NPU)

The standout performer in this setup is undoubtedly the integrated NPU, which HP leans on heavily for local AI acceleration. With up to 50 TOPS of dedicated AI performance, this unit enables real-time transcription, summarisation, background blur in video calls, and even local language model interactions, all without hitting the CPU or GPU.

We tested the NPU with UL's Procyon AI Inference benchmark, where it scored 1406. That's a solid score, outpacing previous-gen AI NPUs from Intel and Apple's M2 lineup in practical inference tasks. The benefit of offloading tasks like document parsing, image processing, or frame correction to the NPU is twofold: lower power consumption and cooler, quieter operation.

When using the HP AI Companion, the NPU helps sort, index, and generate insights from documents in real-time. It feels quick enough for general use, though power users might want more flexibility in controlling the LLM runtime. Enthusiasts will probably note that running Ollama on this laptop makes good use of the 32 GB RAM and benefits from the NPU's presence but